

CAUSE AND CURE

Everybody is talking of inflammation

Inflammation, the body's response to injuries or illness, has become the universal language through which Internet discusses modern life, ageing, food, and the body

MAGAZINE » PAGE 1

What is Karnataka's objection to the Western Ghats ESA?

FAQ » PAGE 8

United Russia: the 'party of power' in Kremlin

PROFILES » PAGE 9

India takes on West Indies in ODI series from today

SPORT » PAGE 14

INSIDE



Trump rejects Iran's deal to reopen Hormuz

WASHINGTON
U.S. President Donald Trump said on Saturday he rejected an Iranian proposal to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, a waterway key to the world's energy supply, and end war in West Asia. » PAGE 12

Cong. raps probe into Ram Temple donation theft

NEW DELHI
The Congress questioned the scope of the SIT probe into the donation theft at the Ram Mandir, asking why key functionaries of the temple's management had not been named as accused. » PAGE 4

EC switches to damage control mode after facing flak over SIR

Poll body announces 'special drive' for enrolment of those left out during the SIR; additional declaration with Form 6 only for the SIR period, it says; decisions, coming days after reports of rift within EC, have 'approval of full commission', it notes

Sheeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

The Election Commission (EC) on Saturday announced a slew of measures addressing concerns over the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls across the country, including stopping physical hearings for unmapped voters or those with logical discrepancies in their enumeration forms.

It said that the declaration accompanying Form 6 (used for fresh voter registration) is mandatory only during the current SIR process. This in effect means that new voters who seek inclusion in electoral rolls after the ongoing SIR need not submit any such declaration.

The Election Commission

Revised process

The EC, which held a meeting on Saturday, said that any person whose name has got left out during SIR or thereafter may apply to the ERO concerned for inclusion in the electoral rolls

KEY DECISIONS

■ Election officers to immediately launch a special drive for enrolment of electors left out of rolls

■ BLOs to visit houses of voters issued notice under SIR

■ A panel with an independent expert from IIT/IIT to review ECINet platform

■ Declaration attached to Form 6 to be used only for SIR

■ Claims and objections period for SIR in Delhi and Maharashtra extended



CEC Gyanesh Kumar with Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi during a meeting in New Delhi on Saturday. ANI

sion also said that any person whose name has got left out during SIR or thereafter, and any person including young/ first-time voters, may apply to the electoral registration officer (ERO) concerned, for inclusion of their names in the electoral rolls.

A special drive will im-

mediately be launched for their enrolment, it said in a press note.

The SIR process has already been completed in 20 States and Union Territories.

The fresh initiatives of the poll body came after a meeting of the full bench of the commission on Sa-

turday afternoon and days after reports emerged of a rift within the Election Commissioners over these and other issues in the SIR process as well as the internal working of the EC.

'Complete approval'

The Election Commission's press note was pertinently

Congress urges top court to hold CEC accountable

NEW DELHI

The Congress on Saturday urged the Supreme Court to take suo motu cognisance of what it described as "illegal and unconstitutional" changes to the voter enrolment process under CEC Gyanesh Kumar while holding him accountable for the changes. » PAGE 3

accompanied by a photograph of all the three Election Commissioners and mentioned that it "has the approval of the full commission".

MORE TIME FOR CLAIMS

» PAGE 3

DISSENT IN THE COMMISSION

» PAGE 9

India slams Sharif's UN speech, asserts right to defend itself

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

Delivering India's National Statement at the UN General Assembly, External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar on Saturday said the country will exercise its right to defend itself against terrorism while focusing on the impact of conflicts on the Global South.

In a response to Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif's speech a day before, where he had criticised India for launching Operation Sindoor last year, Mr. Jaishankar said that there could be "no dilution" of the world's zero-tolerance approach to terrorism. "Yesterday, a serial practitioner of terrorism misrepresented facts before this Assembly. Arguments were invoked to normalise terrorism and claim immunity from its consequences," Mr. Jaishankar said, attacking Mr. Sharif's speech, in which he had called Kashmir the "jugular vein" of Pakistan and accused India of human rights violations in the region.

Mr. Sharif had also claimed that the BJP government unleashed a "reign of terror" against minorities in India.

"Our right to defend against terrorism will be exercised," Mr. Jaishankar said, adding that governments indulging in state-sponsored terrorism with a "cross-border purpose" must be held to account.

Mr. Jaishankar also responded to Mr. Sharif's statement that India is "weaponising water" by holding the Indus Waters Treaty in abeyance.

"Friendship and goodwill cannot co-exist with terrorism. Understandings premised on that will naturally be called into question," Mr. Jaishankar said.



S. Jaishankar

Earlier in the day, Indian and Pakistani diplomats also exchanged sharp words.

On global conflicts

Briefing the UNGA regarding India's position on global conflicts, including the wars in Ukraine and West Asia, Mr. Jaishankar said that countries far from the conflicts were being "penalised for no fault of theirs", referring to the impact on the "Four Fs" of Food, Fuel, Fertilizers and Finance. "Those most impacted often have the least say. This Assembly must face up to the true state of affairs," he added, also referring to the attacks on seafarers in both conflicts, in which 18 Indians have been amongst those killed.

"This is completely unacceptable. India has joined Liberia and 23 other partners in an initiative to rally global public opinion against such unwarranted targeting," he said.

Speaking about Israel's war in Gaza, Mr. Jaishankar said that India believes peace requires a two-state solution and that New Delhi is continuing with its humanitarian efforts and providing relief supplies to Palestinians.

Mr. Jaishankar said that a multi-polar world was on its way, and that the post-1945 order would have to give way to "new realities".

Golden double



Reign continues: The Indian kabaddi teams maintained their supremacy by retaining the men's and women's titles at the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya on Saturday. The men defeated Iran 40-34 and the women pipped the same opponent 37-34 in the finals. R.V. MOORTHY (REPORT: PAGE 13)

China, U.S. agree to cut tariff, launch AI dialogue

Reuters
SHANGHAI

China said on Saturday it had agreed with the U.S. on a \$30-billion reciprocal tariff-reduction arrangement and on launching a dialogue on AI, under an eight-point consensus reached during President Xi Jinping's visit to the U.S.

The two sides also agreed to set up a trade council, China's Foreign Ministry said.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 12

AI system mistakes guitar case for pillion rider, issues challan

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

An artificial intelligence-enabled camera, installed to detect traffic violations in Bengaluru, recently issued a routine helmet violation challan to a not-so-routine defaulter: a guitar case riding on its owner's back.

Souvik Dutta was travelling on his scooter from Hebbal towards Tin Factory with a guitar strapped to his back. The camera apparently mistook the guitar case for a pillion rider and wrongly identified it as a person travelling without a helmet. A challan, along



The photograph involved in the 'false flag' incident in Bengaluru. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

with a photograph captured by the camera, was subsequently sent to Mr. Dutta's wife, who owns the scooter.

The incident has drawn

attention to the limitations of automated traffic enforcement systems. A senior traffic police officer admitted that the reported pillion-rider violation was a 'false flag', caused by an error in judgment by the AI system, which happens occasionally.

Noting that the system has yet to achieve 100% accuracy, the senior officer said that such violations can be questioned, following which they are verified and rectified.

Following the incident, Mr. Dutta raised a complaint on the Bengaluru Traffic Police's official handle on X.

UPSC candidates challenge 'ambiguous' questions

Ashna Butani
NEW DELHI

At least 27 questions in this year's Civil Services Examination (CSE) Prelims have come under dispute, with candidates claiming that the answers in the provisional answer key from the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) are either incorrect, have no correct answer, or allow more than one possible answer.

At least two groups of aspirants have challenged the questions. The cases are being heard by the Central Administrative Tribunal. One group of four candidates has challenged eight questions, while another group of 63 aspirants has challenged 27



Aspirants have flagged at least 27 questions in CSE Prelims held in May this year. FILE PHOTO

questions, including the eight challenged in the first petition. The candidates argued that many of them missed the cut-off for the Mains examination by only a few marks.

The preliminary examination was held on May 24,

and the provisional answer key was uploaded three days later. In June, candidates were informed whether they had qualified for the Mains examination, which was held in August.

On September 9, the Tribunal issued a notice to the UPSC regarding the 27 questions. The two cases will be heard together on October 8.

Disputed queries

Among the questions was one on the Grand Slam tennis tournaments. They claimed that the answer accepted in the provisional key "omits a ranking threshold that the tournaments' own rulebook makes explicit for entry".

Another question con-

cerned the "Zero FIR" procedure under the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023. The candidates alleged that the Hindi version uses a word closer to "investigation", while the English version says "preliminary inquiry".

One of the disputed questions was about agriculture and well irrigation during the Rigvedic period. The question contained two statements, and the candidates were asked to pick the supporting statements given below. The aspirants claimed that the answer they considered correct contradicted the option provided in the provisional answer key.

The question stated that there was evidence from

the Rigvedic period of the use of "ashma chakra" and "ahava" (strapped wooden pails) to draw water. According to aspirants, however, the Ministry of Culture's website states that "ahava" is a trough. They claimed this led candidates to an answer that "goes against established facts in source material".

Another aspect of the same question, the aspirants alleged, contradicted information on the National Council of Museums' website. "The issue may appear obscure, but that is precisely the point: when an exam tests candidates on specific factual distinctions, the answer key must meet the same standard of precision," they said.

INBRIEF



Tiger suspected of killing man in Mysuru captured

A five-year-old tiger, suspected of killing a 65-year-old man at Sanegala village in the Biligiri Ranganathaswamy Temple (BRT) Tiger Reserve in Mysuru, Karnataka on September 14, was captured by the Forest Department early on Saturday. The Director of the Tiger Reserve said that after sustained efforts, the tiger was captured using a tranquilliser dart at around 6.15 a.m. and shifted to the Rehabilitation Centre at Koorgalli for further care and safety.

At Keralam event, journalists stopped from going near CM

The Kochi City police on Saturday allegedly prevented journalists from asking questions to Keralam Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan. The alleged incident happened when TV journalists were waiting for the CM's arrival at an event at a convention centre in Kaloor. As per video aired on TV channels, Peter K.J., Assistant Commissioner, Ernakulam subdivision, prevented the journalists from getting near the Chief Minister, citing security reasons.

Keralam cultural institutions get new chiefs after 4 months

Keralam government ended the four-month leadership vacuum in major cultural institutions, appointing prominent figures from across the fields to head the organisations. Poet and writer Kalpetta Narayanan has been appointed to chairman of the Kerala Sahitya Akademi. Singer and music director G. Venugopal will head the Kerala Sangeetha Nataka Akademi. Actor Prem Kumar has been appointed chairman of the Kerala State Film Development Corporation.

‘CEC advised former Chief Secretary to contest on a BJP ticket’

The Hindu Bureau
PATHANAMTHITTA

Former Keralam Chief Secretary Jiji Thomson revealed on Saturday that Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar had suggested he contest the 2019 Lok Sabha elections on a Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) ticket from Pathanamthitta.

“It was not an offer but a friendly suggestion. I was serving as the Chief Secretary of Keralam and was nearing the end of my career when, on a flight to Delhi, Mr. Kumar asked about my retirement plans. I said I had no such plans whatsoever. It was at this point that he suggested I could contest from the Pathanamthitta Lok Sabha constituency for the BJP,” Mr. Thomson said.

“He said since I belonged to a minority community, I would easily get a Cabinet berth. That was a time when the BJP was looking for Christian candidates in Keralam,” Mr. Thomson added. ‘Friendly suggestion’

Mr. Thomson clarified that it was a friendly suggestion. The conversation took place during a flight to Delhi in the 2015-16 period.

Mr. Thomson also referred to reports speculating that he could get a senior government posting if the UDF returned to power in the State.

“But my priority has always been to focus on Bhaavika, a charitable organisation which runs a student enrichment programme absolutely free of cost,” he said.

Season of misery



Nature's fury: A view of villagers catching fish in floodwaters near Allina village in Andhra Pradesh's Srikulam district on Saturday, as the swollen Nagavali river inundates paddy fields and houses. V. RAJU

SC devotees to mark temple entry centenary in Tirupati

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Former Union Minister and Congress MP Chinta Mohan will lead a delegation of Scheduled Caste (SC) devotees into the Tiruchanoor temple in Tirupati to celebrate the anniversary of the temple entry movement on October 13.

Mr. Mohan, who previously represented the Tirupati Lok Sabha constituency, cited reports in *The Hindu* documenting the historic legal defense by Congress leader C. Rajagopalachari (Rajaji). Rajaji appeared before Tirupati Court Judge V. Ramaswami

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

The High Court of Andhra Pradesh observed that with Amaravati being the only capital of the State by law, the batch of writ petitions challenging the proposed “three capitals”, which came up for hearing on September 25, were now infructuous.

A Bench led by Chief Justice Lisa Gill and comprising Justices Ninala Jayasurya and B.S. Bhanumathi pointed out that an amendment to the A.P. Reorganisation Act of 2014 had granted legal sanctity to Amaravati as the sole capital of Andhra Pradesh.



A.P. had filed an affidavit in SC in 2024 committing to finish projects in Amaravati in three years, State counsel tells HC. FILE PHOTO

Justice Gill said matters that might still be pending would be examined on November 20, while taking note of the likelihood of the appeals filed in the Supreme Court against the High Court’s “Amaravati judgment” dated March 3,

2022, being heard on November 29.

Representing the State, Advocate-General Dammalapati Srinivas informed the High Court that the government had filed an affidavit in the top court in December 2024, expressing

its commitment to complete the infrastructure projects in Amaravati in three years. Accordingly, the works were going on at a brisk pace, and, therefore, the writ petitions must be closed after duly recording the facts, he said.

The counsel for some petitioners said it would be appropriate on the part of the government to settle the issue once and for all by withdrawing the Special Leave Petition filed by the previous YSR Congress Party (YSRCP) government in the Supreme Court against the High Court’s adverse judgment on legislations that facilitated three capitals.

ED demands FIR in CMRL pay-off case

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) informed the Kerala High Court on Saturday that the Keralam Police must register a First Information Report (FIR) to investigate the offences revealed during the ED probe into the CMRL-Exalogic pay-off case.

The ED explained to the Bench that while investigating the offences under the Prevention of Money

Laundering Act, 2002 (PMLA), allegedly committed by T. Veena and her company, Exalogic, they received information regarding a predicate offence, which would fall under the purview of the State police.

The court observed that the ED and the petitioner, lawyer K.M. Shajahan, were unified on the stand that the registration of an FIR was mandatory and there was no scope for preliminary inquiry.

Protest held in Kollam over Amit Shah’s visit

The Hindu Bureau
KOLLAM

Members of the Youth Congress staged a black flag demonstration against Union Home Minister Amit Shah during his visit to Kollam on Saturday.

The incident unfolded outside the Asramam ground in Kollam.

Moments after Mr. Shah’s helicopter landed, demonstrators led by Youth Congress leader Binu Chulliyil marched to-

wards the moving motorcade, leading to a standoff with local Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) supporters.

Police personnel swiftly intervened and restored order.

Later, Mr. Shah travelled onward to inaugurate a National Cooperative Consumers’ Federation of India Limited (NCCF) programme, followed by a visit to Amritapuri, to launch the events to mark the birthday of Mata Amritanandamayi.

Police oppose bail pleas of co-accused in Veeramani case

R. Sivaraman
CHENNAI



R. Veeramani

The Greater Chennai Police (GCP) have filed a counter affidavit before a Special Court for POCSO cases in Chennai, opposing the bail pleas of Shanthi and her husband, Mahendra Simhan, co-accused in the serial child sexual abuse case allegedly involving Gem Granites proprietor R. Veeramani.

The police said the accused were likely to abscond or evade the investigation and trial if released on bail.

According to the police, on October 6, 2025, the Immoral Traffic Prevention Unit of the Central Crime Branch, GCP, received a letter and a pen drive containing information about a video purportedly showing an elderly man physically abusing a girl at a house. The man in the video was later identified as the prime accused, Veeramani, and the crime location as Shanthi’s residence.

Based on the complaint, a case was registered under Sections 7 and 8 of the POCSO Act, 2012. After an investigation, Veeramani was booked for offences such as penetrative sexual assault, while Shanthi and Mahendra Simhan were charged with abetment. All three were arrested on August 29 and remanded in judicial custody.

The police allege that the octogenarian industrialist had sexually assaulted several minor girls, and that the victims’ state-

ments had been recorded under relevant provisions of law.

The case was subsequently altered and additional charges were invoked under Section 5(l) (aggravated penetrative sexual assault) read with Section 6 (punishment for aggravated penetrative sexual assault), Sections 7 and 8 (sexual assault and punishment for sexual assault), Section 15 (punishment for storage of pornographic material involving a child) and Section 21 (punishment for failure to report a case) of the POCSO Act; Sections 354A (sexual harassment), 354C (voyeurism), 201 (causing disappearance of evidence) and 120B (criminal conspiracy) of the Indian Penal Code; and Sections 66E (punishment for violation of privacy) and 67B (punishment for publishing or transmitting material depicting children in sexually explicit acts in electronic form) of the Information Technology Act. A provision of the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989, was also invoked.

Bengaluru AEROs asked to seek ‘citizenship’ documents

Rishita Khanna
BENGALURU

With hearings of notices under the special intensive revision (SIR) under way in Karnataka, Assistant Electoral Registration Officers (AEROs) in Bengaluru said they are being asked to identify voters whom they suspect are foreign nationals from Nepal or Bangladesh and demand “citizenship certificates” from them, even when they produce an Indian passport.

AEROs who spoke to *The Hindu* said that they were “bypassing” these instructions in most cases, but claimed that they were under pressure during weekly meetings, where they were repeatedly told to seek citizenship certificates and no other docu-

AEROs said they were under pressure to ask for citizenship certificates rather than just passports

ments. Explaining their concerns, one AERO said, “If a person has an Indian passport, is it not enough to establish that they are Indian? How do we ask a person who has all the documents to show a citizenship certificate? A citizenship certificate is not even mentioned in the indicative list of documents.”

AEROs said their concern was that if they accepted a citizenship certificate as the only proof, they could be compelled to declare citizens without a citizenship certificate as “in-

eligible voters”.

AEROs also pointed out that a citizenship certificate obtained through naturalisation requires a person to meet a cumulative residence requirement of 12 years.

The AEROs also told *The Hindu* that the last weekly meeting was held on September 25, where several AEROs across different jurisdictions in Bengaluru, objected, arguing that asking for a citizenship certificate could effectively result in citizens being “profiled” or treated as ineligible on that basis.

They said their concerns remained unaddressed. The AEROs said the instructions were given only orally, making it more difficult to demand such documents.

Woman dies after childbirth as floods cut off A.P. village

Harish Gilai
PADERU

A day after giving birth to a boy, a 28-year-old woman in a tribal village of Andhra Pradesh died on Friday as the overflowing streams and a washed-away bridge kept her away from a primary health centre located about six km away, initial reports said.

The floods were triggered by heavy rain caused by a deep depression that crossed the north Andhra coast on Thursday night.

Lavanya, of Gangavaram village in Darakonda panchayat, went into labour on the night of Sep-



Lavanya

ter the heavy rain. The PHC is about 6-km from Gangavaram by the Narsipatnam-Chintapalli-Sileru road.

A bridge connecting the village to the plains had also been washed away. They looked for other routes to take Ms. Lavanya to a health facility, but no vehicle was available because of the continuing heavy rains and the state of the roads, leading to Ms. Lavanya death. The newborn is reported to be safe.

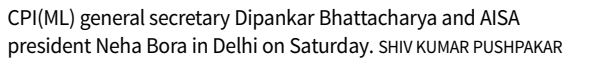
On Wednesday, Joint Collector T. Sripooja had directed the officials across mandals to set up control rooms.

Bandi Sanjay slams CM over remarks on ‘Sangh Parivar’

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Union Minister Bandi Sanjay Kumar lashed out at Telangana Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy over his remarks contrasting the Congress and the “Sangh Parivar”, saying the Congress placed the Gandhi family above the nation. He said: “For us, it is Nation First. For Congress, it is always Family First.”

Earlier, Mr. Reddy spoke about the ideological contest between the “Gandhi Parivar” and the “Sangh Parivar”.



The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

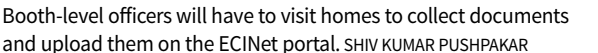
"In four booths, the survey found that of 665 voters deleted during SIR, 77 were living in the village. More than 2,000 voters could have been wrongfully excluded across Ai-

The SKM demanded the immediate removal and prosecution of Mr. Kumar. "The unilateral and authoritarian acts by Gyanesh Kumar as the CEC amount to treason. He should be prosecuted as per law in a befitting manner to serve as a lesson against such probable actions by any belligerent bureaucrats in the future," the SKM said.

Voters in Delhi get time till Oct. 30, while Maharashtra deadline is Oct. 12; booth-level officers to visit unmapped voters; any adult family member can represent voter during online hearing

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

“Such persons need not



As regards new voter re-

A key issue reportedly flagged by the two Election Commissioners was the

Other administrative measures were also announced. These include circulation of an advanced agenda and issuance of minutes for all commission meetings, and approval of the commission for foreign trips of officers.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

“The Supreme Court must immediately take *suo motu* cognisance and hold him accountable,” Mr. Ramesh said in a post on X, referring to Mr. Kumar. He

Meanwhile, the BJP has said that the Congress chose to build its allegations around a manufactured lie to attack the Election Commission. The Congress and other Opposition parties stand exposed for misleading people on the SIR, BJP chief Nitin Nabin said.

Shrabana Chatterjee
Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

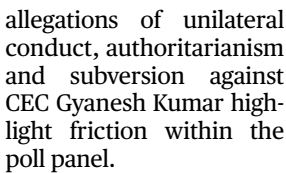
Ms. Banerjee said that Communist Party of India (Marxist) general secretary M.A. Baby had written to

Ms. Banerjee said that at the moment, the whole nation has united against the issue of the CEC's conduct and that Mr. Kumar's days are now numbered.

NEWS ANALYSIS

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The observations of the apex court in *S.S. Dhanoa versus Union of India* (1991), highlighting the importance of a collegial and multi-member EC to democracy, still echo, even as



balances, should not be left in the hands of a single

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The PCI said in the statement that the two journalists were wearing their press IDs at the time. “Ironically, Mr. Lakhera was detained while asking Delhi Police personnel why they were not wearing name tags. While Mr. Lakhera was dragged to the Parliament Street police station and told to delete a picture, which he did not do, before he was let go, Mr. Irfan was taken to the police station in Dwarka and detained for several hours...,” the statement said.

Amit Bhelari
PATNA



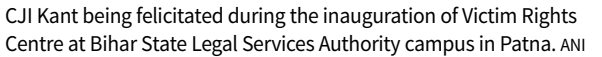
“The State government fails to conduct auctions on time, and it does not seek legitimate revenue for the State’s exchequer. Instead, it desires an increase in personal revenue —

“The primary objective of this Act is to streamline the taxation system in the mining sector and bring transparency. The amendment will curb the arbitrary actions of the State

Ms. Devi pointed out that the MMDR Act has been implemented in States like Odisha, West Bengal, Chhattisgarh, Kar-

Earlier, Mr. Soren termed it a “black Bill” and injustice to Jharkhand and its people. Defending his stance, he had said, “Minerals belong to Jharkhand, land belongs to Jharkhand – so why should Delhi decide on our rights and entitlements?”

Amit Bhelari
PATNA



Though designed to address different needs, the four initiatives are united by a common principle that, “justice must not wait for the citizen to find it; the justice system must find its way to the citizen,” the CJI said.

Explaining the significance of the VRC, the CJI said a victim should not have to understand the law in order to access benefits that the law already guarantees, including compensation, legal and medical assistance, counselling, protection and rehabilitation.

Although these entitlements may exist across different statutes, departments and institutions, their fragmentation can make them difficult for victims to access.

The CJI also highlighted

The multi-utility vehicles launched will take legal awareness, documentation support and first-point assistance to villages and settlements that may be beyond the immediate reach of courts and legal institutions.

The Hindu Bureau
LUCKNOW

"I also demanded that Champat Rai's legal responsibility be determined on the basis of the facts emerging during investigation, and that necessary action be taken in accordance with law," he said.

Why have key Trust functionaries, including Champat Rai and Anil Mishra, been made witnesses, asks Jairam; he questions PM Modi's silence, seeks impartial investigation under SC's supervision

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

In a post on social media

The Congress leader also questioned why Mr. Rai, trustee Anil Mishra, and construction in-charge Gopal Rao had been made

He also questioned the decision to restrict the case to eight accused despite the SIT examining CCTV footage, digital communi-

real responsibility for the theft of offerings made in the name of Lord Ram is fixed," Mr. Ramesh said, calling for an impartial and transparent investigation under the Supreme Court's supervision.

Shiv Sahay Singh
Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

“We had fought in the court for over 15 days just



Attempts were made to disrupt the gathering, the former West Bengal Chief Minister said. "If you [the BJP] have genuinely won in

While Ms. Banerjee has addressed public meetings in Kolkata after her party's Assembly poll debacle, the Sreerampore rally was the first occasion on which she spoke to her supporters in other districts.

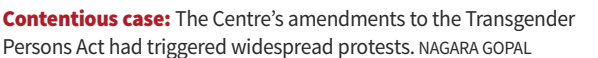
Press Trust of India
UNITED NATIONS

“We are confident that this Assembly will recognise Pakistan and its policies for what they really are; not what its represen-

India had launched Operation Sindoor on May 7, 2025, targeting terror infrastructure in Pakistan and Pakistan-occupied Kashmir, in retaliation for the Pahalgam attack of April 22, 2025, which killed 26 civilians.

Abhinay Lakshman
NEW DELHI

The Centre had introduced amendments to the law earlier this year, removing provisions that guaranteed transgender people the right to their “self-perceived gender identity” and limiting the definition of a “transgender person” to physiological characteristics. The amendments triggered widespread protests across the country and led members of the government’s National Council for Transgender Persons to resign.



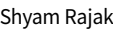
Interestingly, while the Bill was being discussed in the Lok Sabha on March 24, TDP MP Byreddy Shabari was among the MPs of the NDA who had supported it, by raising purported

On the other hand, the BJP-ruled government in Uttarakhnad has defended the 2026 amendments to the law, saying that matters related to rights and health-

that the right to self-determination of gender identity was recognised by the Supreme Court in its landmark NALSA judgment of 2014 and that removing this right was an “attack on Constitutional morality” and the dignity of transgender persons.

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

“Certainly, not just on Bills but on other issues as well, Dalit representatives should be given time to speak so that the issues for which the Poona Pact was reached, and the opposition to which had taken place, do not arise again. Dalits, ordinary members



He said BJP MP Gajendra Singh Patel, who represents the reserved tribal constituency of Khargone in Madhya Pradesh, had pointed out that SC and ST MPs were not being given adequate time to participate in debates on important Bills. Mr. Manjhi urged the Speaker to take steps to address the issue.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

In a statement, the in-charge of BJP's foreign affairs department Vijay Chauthaiwale, said the delegation would meet BJP chief Nitin Nabin, national general secretary (organisation) B.L. Santhosh, and other BJP leaders. "The visit aims to strengthen BJP-JVP engagement," he said.

Press Trust of India
DEHRADUN

The case pertains to alleged irregularities in the 2016 Village Panchayat Development Officer recruitment examination con-

On September 12, Mr. Rawat announced his decision to step down from all party posts after the ED recovered cash and jewellery from his personal assistant's house.

The Hindu Bureau
SRINAGAR

A BJP spokesman said Mr. Sharma apprised the Union Home Minister of matters “related to the prevailing security situation, law and order, development initiatives, public concerns, and matters re-

Mr. Shah reiterated the Union government's commitment to peace, development, and prosperity in J&K and assured Mr. Sharma of continued support and cooperation in addressing matters concerning the people of the Union Territory, the spokesman said. Centre already com-



The meeting between Mr. Shah and Mr. Sharma assumed significance in the wake of the resolution brought in by Mr. Abdullah on the restoration of Statehood to J&K. The resolution also referred to the 2000 report on greater au-

National Conference spokesman Imran Nabi Dar clarified the intention of the resolution. "People of Jammu will not support the stand of the BJP on Statehood. Only way to bring relief to the people of J&K is granting Statehood. Eight BJP MLAs supported the 2000 autonomy resolution. How is it anti-national now? Mr. Abdullah made it clear that the current resolution is about Statehood, a commitment made by the Centre," said Mr. Dar.

Press Trust of India
SRINAGAR

“...today, mosques, shrines, and churches are being demolished... in voter lists, names of Opposition supporters are being removed,” she said on X.

Monitoring Committee for Indian Muslims has decided to protest against these injustices, she said.



In dire straits: A dry tank in Gaadhepalem village near Ongole had left villagers dependent on a well within in. The village's reverse osmosis plant had also become defunct, adding to the problems. KOMMURI SRINIVAS



Welcome sight: A view of the same tank after the rain. The Irrigation Department has now filled the tank with water released from the Ramateertham Reservoir and groundwater level has also improved. KOMMURI SRINIVAS



Ecological distress: The Singarakonda tank near Addanki in Prakasam district is almost completely dried up. The remaining water is visibly stagnant and covered with algae. KOMMURI SRINIVAS



Baked earth: A school student walks across a dry pond to reach a well in Gaadhepalem village. KOMMURI SRINIVAS

After the drought, a refreshing respite

Sharp turn of weather brings relief to parts of Andhra Pradesh, which has been reeling under a severe rainfall deficit, attributed to the El Niño phenomenon

Two days of rain have redrawn a landscape that had borne the effects of a prolonged dry spell, compounded by El Niño-related weather patterns in Andhra Pradesh.

In June, the tank beds in the villages of Alluru and Gaadhepalem near Ongole lay baked and cracked under the summer heat, with concrete wells standing exposed amid the parched earth. Villagers walked long distances with pots and plastic containers to collect drinking water, while cattle wandered across empty lake beds. Now, the same landscape is almost unrecognisable. Fresh rainwater has swallowed the cracked earth, filled the tanks, and turned dusty, barren stretches into shimmering sheets of water. The striking change, captured just days apart, offers a vivid picture of how quickly the landscape can respond when the rains finally arrive.

Heavy rains and increased inflows have replenished water sources across the State.

In Vijayawada, rising inflows into the Krishna River basin prompted the Water Resources Department to lift the gates of the Prakasam

Barrage and regulate the discharge of floodwaters. Officials continued to monitor the inflows and regulate releases as water levels rose.

In Visakhapatnam, the Mudasarlova Reservoir, which had recorded depleted storage earlier, received sufficient inflows following the recent rains. At Gambheeram Gedda Reservoir, too, the contrast is striking. Just two days ago, only a few patches of water were visible in the reservoir. It is now brimming with water.

The change is particularly significant in the tail-end areas of Prakasam district, where several village tanks had dried up during the summer.

To address the shortage during the peak dry period, irrigation authorities in August released water from the Ramateertham Reservoir through the Nagarjuna Sagar Right Canal network to replenish summer storage tanks in the tail-end villages. The water was released specifically to meet drinking water requirements rather than for irrigation, officials said. The recent rains have now filled several of these tanks, covering the exposed beds and improving local water availability.

(Text by G.V.R Subba Rao)



Sudden surge: Gambheeram Gedda Reservoir, which had seen a sharp decline in water levels during the prolonged dry spell, is seen filled to the brim after the recent rains in Visakhapatnam. V. RAJU



Make-shift pitch: Youth playing cricket on the sand dunes formed over the Krishna River. The waterway receded as there was deficit rainfall due to the El Niño effect. There was no discharge from Prakasham barrage owing to poor rainfall in the catchment area. K.V.S. GIRI



Dramatic shift: Fishermen try their luck in the Krishna River after Irrigation officials released water from Prakasam barrage. Due to incessant rains, many rivulets and streams had begun overflowing upstream. K.V.S. GIRI



Splash forward: Water cascading down the steps of the Simhachalam hill following heavy rainfall in Visakhapatnam, under the influence of a deep depression in the Bay of Bengal. K.R. DEEPAK



Rain makeover: The Mudasarlova Reservoir, which had gone almost dry, was seen brimming on September 24, following heavy rains in Visakhapatnam. The inflow and water surge brought tourists to enjoy the scenic view. K.R. DEEPAK



Patchy reserve: Large stretches of the Mudasarlova Reservoir seen dried up, exposing the reservoir bed amid low rainfall, in Visakhapatnam on August 2. K.R. DEEPAK



Wholesome glow-up: An aerial view of Mudasarlova Reservoir in Visakhapatnam on September 25, after the nearly depleted reservoir received fresh inflows following heavy rain. K.R. DEEPAK

PROFILES

Dissent in the Commission

Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi

The two Election Commissioners, both appointed by the government under the new 2023 law, have raised questions about changes to electoral rolls, centralised control and the Election Commission's decision-making process

Sreeparna Chakrabarty

When notices began to be issued after the publication of the draft list during the Delhi SIR [special intensive revision], one of the names was that of Election Commissioner (EC) Sukhbir Singh Sandhu. What was considered ironical on that day and time soon became a moment of reckoning for the poll body as reports emerged that Dr. Sandhu, along with his fellow Election Commissioner Vivek Joshi, had flagged many anomalies in the ongoing SIR process across the country over the last 10 months.

Though rumours of a rift within the Election Commission had been doing the rounds for some months, what came as a surprise were the formal dissent notes written by the two ECs, including one to the Cabinet Secretary, as both had been virtually handpicked by the government under the new 2023 Law for Appointment of the Chief Election Commissioner and Election Commissioners.

The Opposition Congress party had given written objections during the appointment of both in the selection committee meetings. When Dr. Sandhu was appointed along with CEC Gyanesh Kumar on March 14, 2024, following the retirement of EC Anup Chandra Pandey and the abrupt resignation of EC Arun Goel, Congress leader Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury had given a formal dissent note in the selection committee. Later, when Mr. Joshi was appointed on February 17, 2025 after Gyanesh Kumar was elevated to CEC, Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi raised objection in the committee meeting.

Both the Election Commissioners had reportedly flagged several key issues, including the centralisation of the Electoral Rolls. In May this year, Mr. Joshi proposed an audit to certify that “no one except the concerned statutory authorities has any credentials to make any change in the (voter) database”. In August, Dr. Sandhu recorded that State-level election officials were reporting that

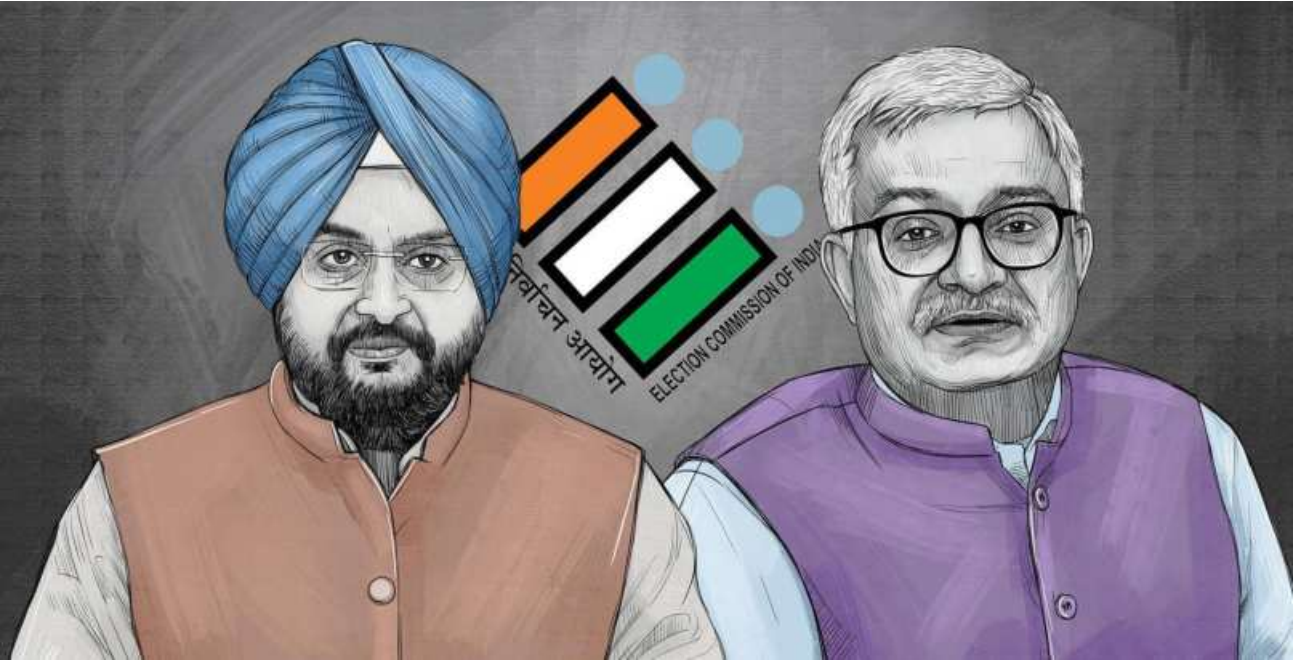


ILLUSTRATION: R. RAJESH

they do not have “proper and complete access” to the ERONet portal – the digital system through which the electoral rolls are maintained. He further flagged that Election Commission Director General of IT “does not have any legal authority to restrict proper and complete access and freedom to operate as given by law to the statutory authorities”.

‘Unauthorised and illegal’

The two ECs also said that Form 6 – which new voters must fill to register– was altered to ask if the applicant or their parents/grandparents “exist” in the electoral roll of the last SIR. They warned as early as May that such a statutory form cannot be changed without amending the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960, and Dr. Sandhu called the change “unauthorised and illegal” in August, demanding its immediate removal. He also questioned who had authorised the Commission in West Bengal to file appeals against voters whom judicial tribunals had already included in the rolls – with 38 lakh appeals pending.

They also flagged the Goa case in which 97 voters, found eligible by local Electoral Registration Officers (EROs)

after a Supreme Court-mandated hearing, were left off the final roll because the centrally controlled software had no mechanism to record the EROs’ decisions. The Chief Electoral Officer’s (CEO) office had written eight times seeking a rollback option.

However, some experts, including former Election Commissioners, have questioned why the two did not seek a meeting of the full Commission and attempt to resolve these issues through a majority vote.

As per provisions of the Election Commission (Conditions of Service of Election Commissioners and Transaction of Business) Act, 1991, which has been carried forward to the 2023 Act, all decisions by the Election Commission have to be unanimous, where possible. But if the CEC and the other Election Commissioners genuinely differ in opinion on a matter, it is to be decided according to the opinion of the majority with each Commissioner (including the CEC) carrying equal weight in the vote. The vote of the CEC does not have any special veto. Dr. Sandhu is a retired 1988-batch IAS officer of the Uttarakhand cadre. Born in 1963, he

holds an MBBS from Government Medical College, Amritsar, a master’s degree in history from Guru Nanak Dev University, and a law degree. He was Chief Secretary, Government of Uttarakhand, from July 2021 to January 2024, where he is credited with having overseen the ideation for implementing the Uniform Civil Code.

He was also Chairman of the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI), Additional Secretary, Department of Higher Education, Ministry of Human Resource Development and Commissioner, Ludhiana Municipal Corporation – for which he was awarded the President’s Medal. He is also an expert on urban reforms and has authored many papers on municipal management. Dr. Sandhu also briefly served as Secretary, Lokpal of India, from February 5 to March 14, 2024, just before he was appointed as an Election Commissioner.

Vivek Joshi was born on May 21, 1966, in Uttar Pradesh. A 1989-batch IAS officer of the Haryana cadre, he’s a mechanical engineer from IIT-Roorkee. He holds a master’s degree in International Business from IIFT, New Delhi, and an MA and PhD in

International Economics from the Graduate Institute, Geneva.

He has served as a Financial Services Secretary and Registrar General and Census Commissioner of India. Earlier, he was member secretary of the Fifth State Finance Commission of Haryana.

Unexpected appointment

When he was appointed EC at 58, he was among the younger members appointed to the poll panel and had taken voluntary retirement before joining the Election Commission, which was considered somewhat unusual.

He himself had called the appointment “unexpected” and noted it was meaningful to him personally as it brought him back to his home cadre (Haryana) briefly before moving to the central body. Mr. Joshi also has family members in the bureaucracy. His brother, Vineet Joshi, a 1992-batch IAS officer, serves as Secretary, Higher Education.

His term runs until February 2031.

Given the seniority order among current commissioners, if Mr. Kumar demits office in January 2029 after retiring, then Mr. Joshi would be the senior-most EC and could succeed him as Dr. Sandhu retires in July 2028. However, if Mr. Kumar has to go before July 2028, Dr. Sandhu becomes the senior-most as he was appointed before Mr. Joshi.

Most importantly, the 2023 Act for appointment of ECs and CEC doesn’t guarantee automatic succession by seniority. Instead, the Act provides a statutory framework for the appointment, tenure, and service conditions of the CEC and ECs, replacing the earlier system governed largely by convention.

There is no clause in the Act that says the senior-most EC automatically becomes CEC when a vacancy arises. Every appointment – including to the post of CEC – goes through this same fresh appointment process unlike the earlier tradition of the next senior-most Election Commissioner being the successor to the incumbent CEC.

THE GIST

▼ In May this year, Joshi proposed an audit to certify that “no one except the concerned statutory authorities has any credentials to make any change in the (voter) database”

▼ In August, Dr. Sandhu recorded that State-level election officials were reporting that they do not have “proper and complete access” to the ERONet portal – the digital system through which the electoral rolls are maintained

▼ However, some experts, including former Election Commissioners, have questioned why the two did not seek a meeting of the full Commission and attempt to resolve these issues through a majority vote

The Arctic race

U.S.-Greenland deal

Washington will establish two new military bases in the world’s largest island as it seeks to expand its presence in the Arctic region and check Russian and Chinese influence

Stanly Johny

“Essentially, it’s a large real estate deal. A lot of things can be done,” U.S. President Donald Trump said in August 2019, during his first term, when asked whether the U.S. would be interested in acquiring Greenland. After he returned to office in January 2025, Mr. Trump repeated his threat. “We need Greenland for national security purposes,” he said in January 2025. You look outside. You have Chinese ships all over the place. You have Russian ships all over the place. We’re not letting that happen.”

Greenland, a Danish territory located between the Arctic Ocean and the North Atlantic Ocean, was home for at least 30 American military bases and installations during the Second World War. The island’s strategic profile grew in recent years after Russia and China stepped up their activities in the Arctic region, partly because of ice melting which opened up previously unpassable regions. Mr. Trump’s threats to take over the island incensed Denmark, a founding member of NATO, and America’s other European allies. The crisis further strained the transatlantic ties. But on September 22, on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly, the leaders of the U.S., Denmark and Greenland



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signed a new security agreement, which, according to Mr. Trump, would allow the U.S. “to do what is necessary in Greenland”.

The 1951 U.S.-Denmark security agreement provides Washington broad rights to build military bases in the ice-covered island. Most American bases on the island were shut down over the years, particularly after the Cold War. Now the U.S. stations some 150 troops at its Pituffik Space Base in Greenland. U.S. officials wanted to increase this military presence which they argued was important to monitor and defend the northern approaches of North America and North Atlantic at a time when the race to control the Arctic is heating up. Russia has extensive Arctic territory and military infrastructure. Greenland also possesses significant mineral resources, including rare earths, a segment which is currently dominated by China. U.S. officials have raised concerns about potential Chinese invest-

ments in Greenland. So Denmark, which has already blocked Chinese investments in Greenland, had said it would allow Washington to expand its military presence on the island, but insisted that Danish sovereignty and Greenland’s self-governing rights be respected. The latest security agreement with the U.S. sought to address both America’s demands and Danish concerns.

Terms of the deal

Denmark, which has already blocked Chinese investments in Greenland, had said it would allow Washington to expand its military presence on the island, but insisted that Danish sovereignty and Greenland’s self-governing rights be respected. The latest security agreement with the U.S. sought to address both America’s demands and Danish concerns.

According to the agreement, even if Greenland, which has a population of around 50,000, becomes independent, it would respect the deal with the U.S. and stay within NATO. In other words, this deal pro-

vides the U.S. indefinite access to the island’s military facilities. The deal, which reaffirms “the sovereignty and territorial integrity of the Kingdom of Denmark” and recognises the “self determination of the people of Greenland”, also stipulates that no hostile power (non-NATO countries) can establish military facilities on the island or invest in its sensitive areas (mainly rare earths). The U.S. will be allowed to establish additional defence facilities in Narsarsuaq in the south, where it had an airfield during the Second World War, and in Mestersvig in the east. The Mestersvig facility would allow the U.S. to monitor the waters between the island and the Scandinavian region. Greenland would also be part of the U.S. Golden Dome anti-missile shield, and Danish authorities have pledged to work together with Washington to counter espionage in Greenland, a reference to alleged Chinese activities in the region.

On paper, Greenland would remain a self-governing territory of Denmark. But in practice, the U.S. would have indefinite rights to build military facilities on the island and a say in its economic policies and resource extraction. Mr. Trump may not have secured ownership of the world’s largest island, but he appears to have secured almost everything else.

The ‘party of power’

United Russia

The political party affiliated to President Vladimir Putin is the big bear that continues to win almost all elections in the country

G.R. Rajeev

Often during his international engagements, the one question that infuriates Russian President Vladimir Putin the most is if Russia is a “managed democracy”. He has been vehement in saying it’s not. “The road to democracy must be adapted to the realities of Russian life, traditions, and history,” Mr. Putin said in February 2005 at a press conference.

But, despite his protestations, democracy in Russia is under intense scrutiny. Mr. Putin’s party, United Russia, is the big bear that wins almost all elections in Russia. In the just-concluded parliamentary elections, United Russia got 349 out of the 450 seats in the Duma, polling 58% of the vote for the 225 seats apportioned by parties and winning 209 single-seat races that fill the other half of the lower chamber of Parliament. The vote, western observers said, was flawed. In August, Russia’s Supreme Court barred Yabloko, the only party running on an anti-war platform, from appearing on the ballot, as polls showed it gaining in popularity and possibly poised to win enough votes to enter Parliament.

The 2024 Presidential election was no different. The result of Russia’s March 15-17 election was



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known to everyone even before the first ballot was cast, *The Hindu* noted in its editorial, as Mr. Putin won nearly 88% of the vote. The country saw a record turnout of 77.44% and the results showed that Russia “is united” under the long-time leader, Ella Pamfilova, Election Commission chief, said. Only Kremlin-tolerated candidates, meaning those who could not challenge Mr. Putin and United Russia, were allowed to contest.

Kremlin party

United Russia, called variously as the “party of power” or for its nebulous ideology, the “big-tent” party, is the Kremlin party, and it’s debatable if the party wants to keep Mr. Putin in power or if it’s the other way. In December 2001, Mr. Putin’s Unity party and Fatherland-All Russia, a leading Opposition group, merged to form an entity which became United Russia in 2003.

As Acting President after Boris Yeltsin resigned six months before the end

of his term on January 1, 2000 and handed over power to him, Mr. Putin, who was Prime Minister before being elevated, went on to consolidate his grip on the state. “Russian democracy now speaks with but one voice. Just 18 months ago, leaders of five ideological factions were waging a pitched public battle to succeed Mr. Yeltsin. Now there is only Mr. Putin, a man of no classifiable ideology beyond building a strong Russia, his rule endorsed by three of every four Russians, according to polls,” the *New York Times* reported on January 21, 2001, after Mr. Putin won the presidency in an election. A few days later, Parliament introduced a Bill that would drastically reduce the number of registered parties from 57 to just six.

The news agency Tass, owned by the Russian government, says United Russia “promotes centrist and conservative ideas, stands for strengthening the country’s sovereignty, increasing its defence capa-

bilities, advancing the patriotic education of young people, enhancing investment, introducing innovative technologies, developing democracy and civil society institutions”. In the 2017 article, Tass reported that the party had two million members.

Under Mr. Putin and United Russia, statism, rooted in Orthodox Christian conservative values, replaced the state-sanctioned communism of the Soviet years, *The Hindu* editorial noted. They mastered a complex model of a tightly held state with regular elections and little dissent. Party leaders variously call it centrist and conservative. Researchers term it Russian integralism. Opposition leaders call United Russia a “party of crooks and thieves”, a phrase popularised by Alexei Navalny, an anti-corruption activist who died in prison.

Gleb Pavlovsky, Putin adviser-turned-critic, is considered the chief architect of the “managed democracy” system in Russia. Vladislav Surkov, former Putin aide called the “grey cardinal” of Kremlin, rebranded it as “sovereign democracy”. The Economist described him as the architect of “a system of make-believe”, involving imitation political parties, stage-managed media, and orchestrated social movements. Mr. Putin, however, is in denial in public.

Chemists report ‘milder’ way to swap carbon for nitrogen atoms

Vasudevan Mukunth

When working with drug candidates, chemists sometimes like to replace a carbon atom in a ring of atoms with a nitrogen atom. This is because the switch can significantly alter the molecule's properties, including how well it dissolves or how it interacts with biological targets in the body. But achieving it has been quite difficult, requiring chemical reactions with powerful

oxidants, say, that can damage other parts of the molecule. A new study in *Science* offers a breakthrough: researchers from the University of Chicago have reported a reaction to replace carbon with nitrogen in types of molecules often encountered in medical research and industry, in “mild conditions”. Chemists had previously banked on a highly reactive intermediate compound called a nitrene to

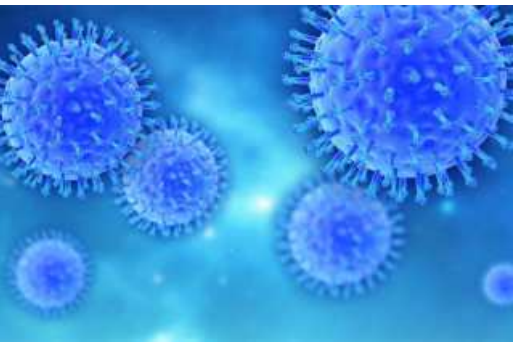
help push a nitrogen atom into a ring. The problem is nitrenes can have different electronic states, one of which – called the triplet state – doesn’t perform the desired reaction. But in the new work, the team set up a series of reactions that used the triplet nitrene state to temporarily open the ring, rearrange the atoms’ positions, and close it such that a nitrogen occurred where a carbon had been. When they tested their technique on a type

of indole that had resisted existing methods, the researchers found the nitrogen-containing version in 73% of the reaction’s yield. After also trying it on other molecules, the team turned to biologically active molecules, which can be quite complex. The team modified one of the cancer-fighting compounds called the Vinca alkaloids to produce a version with nitrogen, which they found had better metabolic properties and less

inhibition of the hERG potassium channel. Finally, the team was also able to produce nitrogen-containing versions of two natural compounds: yohimbine, a veterinary drug, and catharanthine, one of the precursors of the chemotherapy drug vinblastine. This is valuable because synthesising them with nitrogen at the outset can change the molecules’ reactivity, putting paid to established synthetic routes. That said, the

method is not universal, as the authors have acknowledged, and includes toxic compounds called aryl azides among the starting materials. Even so, as they wrote in their paper, “The mild reaction conditions and broad skeletal diversity... lend an unexpected degree of generality to this method”, and they “anticipate that this addition to the toolkit for C-to-N transmutation will find promising applications in medicinal chemistry.”

SNAPSHOTS



PFOS disrupts immune system's antiviral action

PFOS, a widespread industrial ‘forever chemical’, weakens the body’s ability to fight viral infections, a study has found. Researchers found that it binds to an immune protein called IRF3, which keeps it from triggering the release of interferons, our immune system’s top antiviral defence. As a result, viruses can multiply faster. Tests in human cells and mice showed that everyday levels of PFOS exposure led to more severe infections from viruses like influenza and hepatitis B.



IIT-Madras tool bridges quake science and dam safety

An IIT-Madras team evaluated 6,545 dams under India’s National Dam Safety Authority and found standard seismic zone maps misjudge earthquake risks. For Himalayan ‘megadams’ like Tehri and Bhakra, site-specific modelling revealed projected ground accelerations were too conservative. The team achieved this using a combination of a tool it built to perform “probabilistic seismic hazard analysis”, a catalogue of 68,000+ earthquakes from 2,600 BC to 2019, and maps of India’s major faultlines.



Eukaryote sets record for warmest reproduction

Scientists have found a new species of amoeba, *Incandiamoeba cascadenis*, in hot springs in California that has set a record for the upper temperature limit of eukaryotic life. Scientists previously thought these lifeforms couldn’t reproduce above 60° C. However, *I. cascadenis* replicates at 63° C. It activates genes to repair DNA and cell membranes. Its proteins’ chemical properties are such that they don’t clump together, a trick heat-loving bacteria use as well.

Shortening the road to cardiac care in rural Haryana

A tele-ECG project implemented by the govt. in partnership with a startup has made ECGs available at primary, community health centres; patients can get an ECG done, take emergency medication, then be referred to tertiary care centres

Swagata Yadav

In July 15, Raj Rani (52), an ASHA worker in Yamunagar, Haryana, had just completed her tasks for the day when the throbbing pain in her left arm and chin returned.

She headed to the Community Health Centre (CHC) at Vyaspur, 15 km away, for an electrocardiogram (ECG). The additional senior medical officer at the centre, Dr. Gunjeet Singh, checked the ECG results, gave her blood thinners and clotbusters – called a loading dose – and asked her to rush to the district hospital at Ambala Cantonment.

She did, and the cardiologists there performed another ECG and some other tests, and told her she was fortunate to have come to them at the right time.

Ms. Rani had single-vessel disease: a major coronary artery had been blocked. She underwent an angioplasty the next day to release the block.

Two months prior, Mr. Rani would not have received such a quick diagnosis or treatment. Even though the Vyaspur CHC had an ECG machine, there was no technician to conduct it, and while the medical officers could interpret the results, they were not confident.

On May 29, the Haryana government tied up with health technology startup Sunfox Technologies in a

Care closer home

'We are already witnessing a 20% reduction in deaths in district hospital emergency departments'

- In a public-private partnership, Haryana has worked with Sunfox Technologies to install tele-ECG devices in its rural clinics
- These portable machines allow rural health workers to receive reviewed ECG results in under three minutes

Dr. Varun Singh, medical officer, Ranjitpur PHC, Yamunagar, holds up a tablet showing an ECG report. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

- Rapid diagnoses help doctors stabilise heart attack patients with essential medications before referring them to hospitals
- The initiative has already detected many critical cases and significantly reduced emergency room mortality rates
- Although the diagnostic programme is highly effective, experts also emphasise the need for better medical transport infrastructure
- Because India faces immense cardiovascular mortality, officials believe other States should urgently implement this lifesaving technology

public-private partnership to set up a tele-ECG network called ‘Spandan One’. As part of the initiative, each medical centre in Haryana received a tele-ECG device connected to smartphones, which could be operated by frontline workers. Thus, clinician-reviewed results became available in under three minutes.

Almost 600 government facilities, including primary health centres (PHCs), CHCs, sub-divisional hospitals, and district hospitals, have been equipped with these setups. Per the Spandan dashboard, as of September 17, 33,854 ECG tests had been conducted and 1,342 critical cases detected. In the remote Ranjitpur PHC in Yamunagar, there has been a steady increase in the number of patients seeking to avail the tele-ECG service.

“Before this initiative, I

would not be able to interpret ECGs with this level of sophistication. The patient would need to visit a cardiologist available two hours away and wait a long time in the OPD for the diagnosis,” medical officer Dr. Varun Singh said.

While PHCs are the first point of contact for medical care for rural patients, the centres lack the requisite equipment and human resources to diagnose and treat heart ailments. And the time lost to travelling between centres can prove fatal for many patients.

“We are already witnessing a 20% reduction in deaths in the emergency departments of district hospitals because patients are being stabilised before rushing here,” Dr. Kuldeep Singh, former Director-General of Health Services (DGHS), Haryana, and the person who conceived the partnership, said.

There are now ECG machines and early treatment in rural centres that had earlier not registered a single heart attack due to lack of diagnosis, he said. Once patients are stabilised by the loading dose, they are sent to higher centres like district hospitals with catheterisation labs, where angiographies and angioplasties can be performed.

“With Haryana, we are trying to build that complete pathway – from diagnosis to prescription to referral – while giving the State real-time visibility into its cardiac burden,” Rajat Jain, Sunfox CEO Rajat Jain said.

The Dehradun-based company designs and manufactures portable, affordable diagnostic tools to solve healthcare challenges. Under its agreement with the Haryana government, it also provides equipment, training, and

ongoing support for the tele-ECG system and maintains a live dashboard.

Dr. Chetanya Malik, who practices in Surguja in Chhattisgarh for the non-profit Sangwari, said that while making ECG facilities available at PHCs is a great start, more needs to be done.

“Along with a tele-ECG facility, there needs to be tele-support in finding transport and referral in higher centres to solve the problem of treating a cardiac emergency,” he said. The question of what happens when the partnership between the government and Sunfox ends also remains open.

India records 31 lakh deaths every year due to cardiovascular causes. Some 60% of them occur in people aged 40-69 years, with Indians on average reporting the effects of heart disease a decade earlier than in the west. Timely treatment during the ‘golden hour’ after an emergency can significantly improve survival and recovery. “We have the funds and have the technology to prevent the deaths; there is no reason why other States should not implement this programme and tackle heart emergencies,” Dr. Singh, the former DGHS, said.

(This article is the third of a three-part series on the health system's response to heart attacks. This series is a project of Nivarana, a digital public health platform and has been supported by Sunfox Technologies)

How wealth shapes our view of artificial intelligence



John Xavier

There’s a common assumption that anxiety about artificial intelligence is universal – that everyone, everywhere, is bracing for the same disruption. But, a new Pew Research Centre Survey of over 42,000 adults across 37 countries suggests otherwise.

The survey’s data points out that worry about AI tracks closely with wealth. The richer the country, the more its people fear AI will take their jobs, widen inequality, and disrupt daily life. The poorer the country, the less its citizens fear AI as they simply haven’t formed an opinion on it yet.

Per capita income, it turns out, may be the single best predictor of how a population feels about AI.

The researchers split 36 core countries into 18 “high-income” and 18 “middle-income” nations, using World Bank’s classifications built on gross national income per capita. The gap between the two groups shows up in nearly every question that was part of the survey.

A median of 55% of adults in high-income countries said AI will lead to fewer jobs in their country over the next decades. In middle-income countries, that figure drops nearly 20 points lower to 36%. People in poorer countries aren’t necessarily more hopeful; they’re more uncertain.

Roughly a third of the adults in middle-income nations said they simply don’t know how AI will affect jobs, compared with about a fifth in wealthy ones.

The same pattern holds for inequality. A median of 35% of adults in high-income countries believe AI



Divergence in attitudes of people seems to be a function of the level of awareness of new technologies. GETTY IMAGES

will widen the gap between rich and poor, versus 22% in middle-income countries.

In general, 40% of the respondents in the wealthy nations said they were more concerned than excited about AI’s growing presence in their daily lives, compared with 31% in middle-income nations.

When the researchers plotted individual countries against their GDP per capita, the correlation between GDP per capita and the belief that AI cost jobs was strong. On AI aware-

ness – the share of people who said they’ve heard or read ‘a lot’ about AI – the connection was even stronger.

Respondents in two Asian nations capture this divide. In Singapore, for instance, where GDP per capita is close to \$100,000, 53% of its adults said they’ve heard or read ‘a lot’ about AI. In Bangladesh, where GDP per capita is about \$2,600, just 4% of its adults reported the same level of awareness.

Loss of job loss follows the same pattern as rough-

ly seven in ten or more adults in Australia, South Korea and the U.S. expect AI to shrink the job market over the next two decades. But in Kenya, Nigeria and the Philippines, that expectation is far less common as they are yet to form a strong view on the technology.

Nearly half of Americans said the technology will widen the gap between rich and poor. In India, however, which is classified as a middle-income country, only 13% said the same.

This divergence in attitudes of people in high-income and middle-income economies seems to be a function of the level of awareness of new technologies.

People in advanced economies are far more likely to have encountered AI tools directly that have visibly threatened their job prospects.

In middle-income nations, however, where in-

formal labour and manual work still make up a large share of employment, AI’s impact can feel more abstract.

Pew Research Centre found that in many middle-income countries, it’s the wealthier and more educated people within that country who are most likely to say AI will cost jobs or deepen inequality.

Much of the gap traces back to the same driver: people with less income and less formal education are simply more likely to say they’re unsure of this technology. Uncertainty fills the space where worry would otherwise occupy.

The implication of this survey is double-edged for citizens and governments. Concern is often what drives demand for regulation and worker protections. That means the countries best positioned to frame laws around AI’s disruptions may be exactly the ones already feeling the most anxious about it.



Question Corner

Feel the music

Why is some music able to make us cry?
— Radhika S., Mumbai

A good song can make us cry because listening to it simultaneously invokes parts of the brain involved in emotion, memories, expectations, and arousal. As we listen, the brain constantly predicts what will come next, from a melody resolving itself to a voice reaching a particular high note. When the song suddenly fulfils or violates these expectations, the resulting build-up and release of tension can trigger strong physiological reactions. We also associate music with autobiographical memories. When we

repeatedly hear a specific sequence of rhythm, timing, lyrics, etc., the brain stores it alongside whatever else it is encoding then. When you hear the opening notes later, it can trigger the brain to recognise the old sensory pattern and ‘activate’ the larger network of information stored with it. Sadness can also produce changes grounded in shared physiology. When people observe these cues alongside sadness, their brains learn the association. So, people can be brought to cry to unfamiliar music, too.

Readers may send their questions / answers to science@thehindu.co.in

Business

INBRIEF



Captive coal plants directed to maximise power output

India has ordered more than 100 captive coal-fired power plants to operate at maximum capacity from October 1 through year-end to meet what it expects will be a rise in electricity demand. The federal power ministry's order, invoked under emergency provisions of the Electricity Act, applies to plants with installed capacity of at least 50 megawatts. The aim is to meet an "expected rise in electricity demand in the coming months," showed the order. REUTERS

NTPC, EDF sign pact to develop RE projects in India

State-owned NTPC and EDF Power Solutions India have joined hands to jointly develop, own and operate pumped storage projects, hydropower projects, as well as other renewable energy (RE) projects and distribution business. This 50:50 JV shall undertake projects within India and neighbouring countries, NTPC said. The JV agreement was signed in the presence of NTPC Chairman Gurdeep Singh and Bernard Fontana, Chairman and CEO, EDF SA, France. PTI

DHL Express to hike charges by 8.9% in India from Jan.

Logistics operator DHL Express on Saturday announced an 8.9% increase in its shipment charges in India from January 1 next year. The annual price hike enables the company to adjust for some of the increased costs arising from various factors such as inflationary pressures, currency fluctuations, and industry-specific cost developments. DHL Express said it adjusts its prices annually to account for inflationary pressures and currency fluctuations. PTI

Truck makers widen reach as freight enters small towns

Balasubramanyam C.P.
CHENNAI

India's commercial vehicle makers are looking beyond traditional transport hubs as freight activity expands into smaller towns and regional markets.

BharatBenz's recent dealership launch in Supaul, Bihar, reflects this shift. The four-bay 3S (sales, service and spares) facility on NH-327A will serve Supaul, Araria, Madhepura and adjoining districts, with an annual service capacity of around 1,800 vehicles. Daimler India Commercial Vehicles (DICV) manufactures BharatBenz trucks and buses.

BharatBenz President and Chief Business Officer, Domestic Sales and Customer Service, Rajiv Chaturvedi said it is witnessing "strong momentum across smaller towns and emerging freight corridors" due to growth in manufacturing, agriculture, infrastructure, e-commerce and regional distribution networks.

Ashok Leyland is witnessing a similar trend, with freight movement becoming more distributed across markets, according to Sanjeev Kumar, President, M&HCV Division. Smaller towns are emerging as important logistics centres, supported by rural consumption, MSME activity, organised retail and sectors such as dairy, fisheries and agriculture.

Improved connectivity is driving this transition. India's national highway network expanded from 91,287 km in March 2014 to 1,46,572 km by February 2026, while the share of highways with less than two lanes declined from 30% to 9%. Better roads are reducing travel time,



Better roads are reducing travel time and connecting smaller production centres with larger consumption markets. FILE PHOTO

improving truck utilisation and connecting smaller production centres with larger consumption markets. A study cited by the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways found that highway projects implemented between 2014 and 2022 reduced transport time between factories and suppliers by 9.19% and between factories and customers by 4.93%. Access to agricultural mandis also improved by 7%.

For truck makers, this expansion creates a new challenge: ensuring that vehicles sold in smaller markets receive the same level of service support available in major cities.

Service differentiator Commercial vehicle customers increasingly value uptime as much as the vehicle itself. A truck that spends less time in a workshop directly improves operator profitability.

BharatBenz is expanding through a mix of integrated 3S facilities, smaller 2S outlets and mobile service formats. It currently has over 430 touchpoints and plans to expand the network to 600 by 2030, with a focus on northern, eastern and northeastern India. Ashok Leyland is following a similar strategy through dealerships, authorised service centres, mobile service vans and digi-

Vedanta seeks revival of Niyamgiri

Post discussion with Odisha CM, Anil Agarwal says bauxite mining project shelved in 2013 after resistance by the Dongria Kondh community to be reopened immediately; he also commits ₹1 lakh crore investment in various projects in the State

Satvasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

Vedanta Group Chairman Anil Agarwal on Saturday sought the reopening of the Niyamgiri bauxite reserves in Odisha, nearly 13 years after mining plans were shelved following opposition from the Dongria Kondh community, a Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Group (PVTG).

"The discussion [with Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi] today was that Niyamgiri would be reopened immediately. The tribal population there should be given employment opportunities and brought into the development process," Mr. Agar-



Talking business: Odisha CM Mohan Charan Majhi with Vedanta Group Chairman Anil Agarwal on Saturday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

wal said after discussion with Odisha government at State secretariat.

The Niyamgiri Hills are estimated to hold 72 million-88 million tonnes of bauxite, a key raw material for alumina and alumi-

um production.

"The Niyamgiri bauxite reserves that were guaranteed to us should be opened to mining. We have been told that all the necessary permissions currently required will be granted

Over 10% economic growth possible for India, says FM

Mini Tejaswi
BENGALURU

India can achieve economic growth of more than 10%, but reaching that level will require stronger efforts across sectors, including startups, technology and agriculture, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said on Saturday.

Speaking at a fireside chat at Sangam 2026, the annual fest of the IIT Madras Alumni Association in Bengaluru, Ms. Sitharaman said higher growth would accelerate India's



Nirmala Sitharaman

journey towards an Atmanirbhar Bharat and Viksit Bharat. "It is possible for us to reach 10-plus growth. I am not just saying it to pep you all up. It is possible, but it would require a lot more effort from all sta-

keholders," she said.

Sitharaman said India had significant headroom to raise growth by opening new avenues for talent and technology and applying innovation to persistent economic challenges. The startup ecosystem, which has expanded rapidly since 2015, could make a much larger contribution to economic growth in the coming years, she said.

She also called for greater optimism about India's economic progress, saying the country had "too many naysayers".

Centre notifies Kandla, JNPA, Mundra and Paradip as mega ports

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Centre has notified Deendayal (Kandla), Jawaharlal Nehru (Nhava Sheva), Paradip and Mundra ports as mega ports under the Indian Ports Act, 2025.

The notification was issued by the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways on September 25, 2026, and came into force on its publication in the Gazette of India.

Deendayal, Jawaharlal

Nehru and Paradip are major ports. Mundra, operated by Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone, is a port other than a major port. The major ports were notified under Section 73 (2) of the Act and Mundra under Section 73(3).

The notification states that the four ports satisfy the criteria for classification as a mega port.

These criteria were notified on July 30, 2026 in consultation with State governments.

Centre to set up first port-based e-methanol production facility at Kandla for ₹2,300 cr.

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

In a boost to maritime decarbonisation, the government on Saturday laid the foundation stone for its first port-based e-methanol production facility at Kandla, involving an investment of ₹2,300 crore.

The 150-tonne-per-day green fuel plant – a joint venture between the Deendayal Port Authority (DPA) and Assam Petro-Chemicals Ltd. (APCL) – will supply cleaner fuel to international vessels navigating the busy Asia-Europe trade corridor.

India is moving up as the world's leading maritime power and it will now power the world's ships with green energy, Union

The plant will use renewable power, water and biogenic CO2 to produce e-methanol

Shipping Minister Sarbajit Sonowal said.

Mr. Sonowal was speaking at an event to lay the foundation stone for the country's first port-based e-methanol plant at Deendayal Port Authority (DPA) in Kandla, Gandhidham, Gujarat.

According to an official statement, the 150-tonne-per-day plant will use renewable power, water and biogenic CO2 to produce e-methanol, a green fuel that will enable cleaner shipping, and supply it to ves-

sels plying on the Asia-Europe International Trade Corridor, one of the world's busiest trade routes.

The project positions India as an exporter of green fuel to global shipping, it added.

According to the statement, the plant will position India as a global leader in the production and supply of green fuel, and will produce green methanol at a much more competitive rate compared to other global producers, just ₹750 per tonne, against a global rate of \$1,300 per tonne.

The ₹2,300 crore plant is a joint initiative of Deendayal Port Authority (DPA) and Namrup-based Assam Petro-Chemicals Ltd. (APCL), and will be in-

Indian non-profits lag on digital maturity, AI

Aroon Deep
NEW DELHI

Non-profits lag on technological maturity in India, a new report based on a survey of 500 organisations in the sector said.

Even as white collar organisations employing college-educated workers experiment heavily with AI and integrate it into their workflows, non-profits did not score even 50% on digital maturity, even as they showed some interest in using large language models (LLMs) to help with reports and marketing, Delhi-based Digital for Nonprofits (D4NP) said in its State of Nonprofits Digitization Report 2026.

'Always the last'

In any industry, D4NP founder and former Google executive Abhinav Chetan said, "non-profits are always the last, no matter which technological trend you pick ... They're still experimenting. They're still at level one, by the way – they're only using it for conversations. They're not really using it for complicated workflows."

While AI systems have made it far easier for organisations to do routine work faster, Mr. Chetan said that many were lagging behind on even the earlier digitisation wave.

One example the report cited was most organisations not taking advantage of monthly \$10,000 ad grants. That came out to millions of dollars of free advertising money simply lying unused.

CCPA imposes ₹10 lakh penalty on Amazon, Flipkart; ₹5 lakh on JioMart

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA) has imposed penalties of ₹10 lakh each on Amazon and Flipkart, and ₹5 lakh on JioMart, for selling and advertising an unregistered agro-chemical product.

The collaboration is aimed at international shipowners.

Synergy manages more than 750 vessels and employs over 32,000 seafarers through 31 offices in 15 countries. It has supported the delivery of more than 250 newbuilding projects. Its current portfolio covers over 150 vessels under construction at 20 shipyards in six countries.

The group has also converted LNG carriers into floating storage and regasification units (FSRUs).

The penalty was for selling, advertising an unregistered agro-chemical product

the platforms to conduct a self-audit to prevent listings of products that contravene existing law or pose a hazard to consumer safety, and asked them to submit compliance reports within 15 days of the order.

Forwarded plaint

The investigation was triggered after the CCPA received a complaint forwarded by the Union Ministry of Agriculture, originally filed by the Crop Care Federation of India (CCFI). During the probe, the Agriculture Ministry in-

formed the CCPA that no chemical by the name "Cyclosinone" is listed in the Schedule to the Insecticides Act, 1968, meaning the product's sale and marketing bypassed mandatory safety, bio-efficacy, quality and legal checks required under the law.

The CCPA noted that the marketplaces had not carried out adequate independent verification of the product's regulatory status before allowing the listings to go live.

In its order against Amazon, the regulator cited 38,410 orders involving 43,634 units, with an aggregate sale value of ₹96,42,572/- as evidence of the scale of consumer exposure and the misleading impression created among buyers.

Anmol files DRHP with SEBI for ₹1,800 cr. IPO

Press Trust of India
KOLKATA

Kolkata-based Anmol Industries has filed its Draft Red Herring Prospectus (DRHP) with SEBI for an Initial Public Offering (IPO) to raise up to ₹1,800 crore.

The IPO, with a face value of ₹5 per equity share, is entirely an offer for sale (OFS) of equity shares aggregating up to ₹1,800 crore by the promoter entity Baijnath Choudhary & Family Trust.

The company will not issue any fresh shares and will not receive any proceeds from the offering.

The offer is being made through the book-building process.

Russian, Ukrainian strikes leave 10 dead; Kyiv hits oil, industrial sites



Saudi coalition says it intercepted Houthi drones headed for Riyadh



Trump shares Pak. PM's UN speech over 'halting Operation Sindoor'



OpenAI says its AI agents posted user images online in error



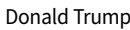
The two leaders agree to set up a trade council and extend outcomes of earlier talks in Kuala Lumpur; they launch dialogue on AI risks and benefits; Beijing says it valued Washington's use of term 'super intelligence' instead of 'artificial intelligence'

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The three-day summit

Dialogue on AI

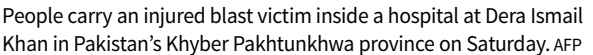
Reuters



Reuters

UNITED NATIONS

Emergency personnel look for survivors in the rubble of a building that partially collapsed following an explosion due to gas leak in the Plaka area, which is popular with tourists, in central Athens, Greece, on Saturday. Rescuers recovered six bodies during the search. REUTERS

 A IN-X

INCREDIBLE INAMDAR

‘Didn’t even have food at home, now I have two Asiad medals’



REUTERS

It still feels like a dream to me. I often think about how someone who didn’t even have food at home now holds two international (Asiad) medals. I want young, underprivileged players to dream big and aim to achieve even more than I have — Aslam Inamdar, right in pic, after winning his second successive Asian Games gold.

PERFECT RECORD

Indian men’s hockey team edges Japan, books semifinal berth



AHF

Defending champion India advanced to the semifinals of the Asian Games men’s hockey competition after defeating Japan 2-0 in a Pool A contest in Kakamigahaa on Saturday. Abhishek scored a field goal in the 15th minute while skipper Harmanpreet Singh converted a penalty corner in the 40th. This was India’s fourth straight win.

REWARDED

‘Shifting to marathon would have been a waste of time without this’



REUTERS

Sawan Barwal said that shifting to marathon earlier this year would have been a “waste of time” had he not won a medal at the Asian Games in Nagoya. “This medal is very precious. If I had not won this medal, it would have been meaningless and a waste of time. This is a big achievement for me,” Sawan said after his silver show.

TALKING TOUGH

There will be an enquiry: AFI on Jyothi and Praveen’s pull outs



FILE PHOTO: RITU RAJ KONWAR

The AFI has taken a dim view of the absence of hurdler Jyothi Varraji and triple jumper Praveen Chithravel at the Asian Games on Saturday. “There will be an enquiry. We will look into all the details and then take whatever action might be needed,” AFI spokesperson and former president Adille Sumariwalla told *The Hindu*.

Indian kabaddi teams dominate with double gold

Both defeat perennial rival Iran to retain titles; the men’s side fights back from a one-point deficit at half-time while the women’s outfit keeps its cool in the final phase to come up trumps

ASIAN GAMES

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

Three years ago, the Indian men’s kabaddi team had won an ill-tempered, farcical and close Asian Games final against perennial rival Iran that went into the history books as a lesson on how not to conduct a competition.

On Saturday, the teams played out yet another title clash but things were far more subdued with India winning 40-34 for its ninth gold in 10 editions and reiterating its absolute chokehold on the sport.

Reliable medal hope

With the women retaining their medal from Hangzhou with a 37-34 victory — also against Iran — the gol-



This is who we are! The men’s and women’s kabaddi teams doubled India’s gold tally by living up to the billing on Saturday. R.V. MOORTHY & ANI

den double ensured kabaddi remains India’s most reliable medal hope at the Games.

An India-Iran encounter in the men’s final was expected, nay assumed from the moment the draw had been made. The two po-

werhouses are miles ahead of the rest and any challenge to India’s superiority could only come from the Iranians. The title decider lived up to its billing.

India and Iran traded points early on and were content staying level with-

out getting too adventurous in both attack and defence. Arjun Deshwal and Devank Dalal led India’s raids while captain Sunil Kumar, along with Jaideep and Sumit, held firm in defence.

Amirmohammad Zafar



Danesh completed an all-out and the contest remained in balance with Iran taking a one-point lead into half-time. Post break, India regrouped: a super tackle and a successful raid by Aslam Inamdar helped India level the

score at 20-20.

Iran skipper Fazel Atrachali and Omid Khojasteh Mohammadshah mounted a brief recovery while Ali Samadi tried to earn raiding points. But the turning point came when Arjun set up an all-out that opened

up a five-point cushion for India with 10 minutes remaining.

Leading 39-32 with under 20 seconds left on the clock, India sealed gold in emphatic fashion.

Earlier, the India women’s team had to fight off

Medals table

	Country	G	S	B	T
1	China	107	41	28	176
2	Japan	31	49	49	129
3	South Korea	16	21	36	73
4	Uzbekistan	8	17	9	34
5	Kazakhstan	8	8	19	35
10	India	4	12	14	30

a stiff challenge from the 2018 champion for a narrow three-point win. It dominated the first half, at the end of which it led 22-16.

But Iran went on the offensive in the second period, reducing the margin. Pooja and Sanju Devi worked tirelessly, one point at a time, in every raid, as India stayed ahead before retaining the title.

Sawan bags marathon silver; Tajinderpal finishes second; Prachi pulls off a surprise



One to cherish: Sawan bettered his own National record while Prachi managed a podium finish. AP & PTI



Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

A day that began with the longest competitive distance in athletics producing one of the most precious medals for India ended with questions around selections and accountability of absentee athletes that overshadowed the impressive performances of those who did turn up to do their best.

Saturday morning at the Asian Games here saw Sawan Barwal, a man who started running marathons only a year ago, break not only his own National record by an incredible 21 seconds (2:11:37s) but also win India’s first Games silver in the event in 44 years. He had already shattered one of the longest standing records in Indian athletics, Shivan Singh’s 1978 timing of 2:12:00, by running 2:11:58 in April.

More importantly, this is only the fourth Indian me-



Tajinderpal. PTI

dal in Asiad marathon and the first outside the country. For a while, it looked like the 28-year-old could go all the way before Japan’s Ichitaka Yamashita (2:10:49) edged ahead in the home stretch.

In the evening, Tajinderpal Singh Toor failed to complete his hat-trick of Asian Games gold, settling for silver at the Paloma Mizuho athletics stadium in incessant rain and cold weather. Tajinderpal managed a best throw of

20.64m on his fifth attempt but could not get past Iran Mohammadreza Tayebise, who set a new Games record of 20.81m, for the top spot.

Prachi Choudhary was a surprise bronze medallist in women’s 400m (53.21s), but the rest disappointed.

Karthik Unnikrishnan was sixth in triple jump (16.02m) while Kiran Pahal was fifth in 400m (53.41s). Vishal T.K. was placed fifth among the men’s 400m (45.48s) and Parul Chaudhary, despite a personal best of 4:09.46, could only manage fourth in women’s 1500m.

Tejaswin Shankar, meanwhile, was leading the decathlon charts with 4,338 points after five events.

But eyebrows were raised when Jyothi Varraji, silver medallist in 100m hurdles last time around, and National record holder triple jumper Praveen Chithravel both pulled out of the competition.

THE INDIA SHOW

A look at some Indian performances on Saturday:

Athletics: Men: Marathon final: Sawan (silver), Kartik (17th); Shot put final: Tajinderpal (silver), Karanveer (10th); 400m final: Vishal (fifth); Triple jump final: Karthik (sixth); 200m semifinals: Animesh (second in heat 3), qualified for the final; 1500m: Yonus (third in heat 1) and Gulveer (third in heat 2), both qualified for the final. Women: 400m final: Prachi (bronze), Kiran (fifth); 1500m final: Parul (fourth), Pooja (sixth); 200m: Harita (second in heat 2) and Unnathi (third in heat 3), both qualified for the final; 100m hurdles: Nandhini (fourth in heat 2), qualified for the final.

Badminton: Men: Third round: Ayush lost to Chou (Tpe) 1-2; Second round: Lakshya lost to Yew (Sgp) 1-2; Women: Third round: P.V. Sindhu bt Miyazaki (Jpn) 2-0; Unnati bt Wardani (Ina) 2-0; Doubles: Second round: Treasa & Gayatri bt Mayu & Yuki (Jpn) 2-0.

Boxing: Round-of-16: Men’s 55kg: Jadumani lost to Paalam (Phi); Men’s 90kg: Kapil bt Estaki (Iri); Women’s 60kg: Priya bt Yeonji (Kor).

Hockey: Men (Pool A): bt Japan 2-0.

Kabaddi: Finals: Women: bt Iran 37-34; Men: bt Iran 40-34.

Shooting: 50m rifle 3P women individual final: Tilottama (fourth), Vidarsa (fifth); Team final: Silver (Tilottama, Ashi, Vidarsa).

Squash: Semifinals: Men: Abhay bt Irfan (Pak) 3-0; Women: Anahat bt Watanabe (Jpn) 3-2; Mixed doubles: Velavan & Joshna lost to Yi & Hong (Hkg) 1-2, bagged bronze.

Table tennis: Round 3: Women: Yashawini lost to Harimoto (Jpn) 1-4; Men: Manush lost to Lin (Chn) 0-4.



Sindhu. GETTY IMAGES



Productive day: Tilottama, Vidarsa and Ashi totalled 1,763 to take the second spot. PTI

India bags silver in women’s 50m rifle 3P

Press Trust of India
NAGOYA

The Indian trio of Tilottama Sen, Vidarsa Vinod and Ashi Chouksey won the silver in women’s 50m rifle 3P team event at the Asian Games here on Saturday.

Tilottama finished fourth in the individual final while Vidarsa was fifth. The latter was also part of the 10m air rifle team which won a silver to open India’s account in this edition.

The Indian team aggregated 1,763 to finish second on the podium. China claimed the gold medal with a Games record total of 1,773.

Kazakhstan ended with

the bronze (1,754). In the individual final, Tilottama was crestfallen after a 9.4 at a crucial stage of the contest put paid to her hopes of finishing on the podium one more time.

The 18-year-old, who was leading after the first 25 shots in the final and was placed third after 30 shots, ended the competition with 337.3 followed by Vidarsa (327.4).

New high

China’s Jiayu Han won the gold medal with an Asian record of 359 and her compatriot Liyuan Zhang (358.8) took home the silver. South Korea’s Jieun Kim (348.4) bagged the bronze medal.

Tough for Anahat, easy for Abhay; Joshna-Velavan lose

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

Anahat Singh has made it a habit of creating history and the reigning junior World champion added another to her list on Saturday, becoming the first Indian woman to make the Asian Games squash final.

On the men’s side, Abhay Singh reached the title decider, both Indians setting up title clashes with the reigning champions.

Anahat’s 3-2 (9-11, 11-13, 12-10, 11-6, 11-3) win, coming in 51 minutes after being 0-2 down against World No. 6 and local favourite Satomi Watanabe, was incredible as much for her fightback as her composure — the only time she had any reaction was after winning the third game, letting out a triumphant scream. The 18-year-old Anahat looked tentative starting out, trying to play cautiously, and was content with not letting her opponent run away with easy points.

It was a contrast to the men’s semifinal that followed, Abhay winning 3-0



Joshna and Velavan... a bronze medal. R.V. MOORTHY

(11-3, 12-10, 11-6) against Pakistan’s Mohd. Irfan with only a brief struggle towards the end.

Earlier, Joshna Chinappa and Velavan Senthilkumar were practically robbed of a place in the mixed doubles final and had to finish with a bronze.

Unfortunate

The duo fought back from a game down and looked like they had won their semifinal against Lee Ka Yi and Tang Ming Hong of Hong Kong before the winning point in the final game was overturned.

They eventually lost 10-11, 11-2, 10-11.

INDIANS IN ACTION

A look at some Indian players/teams who will compete on Sunday (all times IST):

Athletics: Women’s marathon race walk final (Manju, Priyanka), 4 a.m.; Men’s decathlon (Tejaswin, Thowfeeq), 7.30 a.m. onwards; Men’s 400m hurdles heats (Santhosh, Yashas), 8.35 a.m.; Women’s 400m hurdles heats (Vithya, Anu), 9.05 a.m.; Men’s long jump qualification (David, Sreeshankar), 9.10 a.m.; Women’s long jump final (Ancy, Shaili), 3.25 p.m.; Men’s 200m

final (Animesh), 4.05 p.m.; Men’s high jump final (Sarvesh, Aadarsh), 4.15 p.m.; Women’s 100m hurdles final (Nandhini), 4.50 p.m.; Men’s 800m heats (Afsal, Krishan), 5 p.m.; Women’s 3000m steeplechase final (Parul, Ankita), 5.50 p.m.; Women’s 4x100m relay heats, 6.15 p.m.; Women’s 4x400m relay heats, 7 p.m.

Badminton: Mixed doubles (quarterfinals): Dhruv & Tanisha vs. Zhe & Dongping (Chn), 6.10 a.m.

Boxing: Quarterfinals: Men’s 80kg: Ankush vs. Salimov (Tjk), 9.45 a.m.; Women’s 65kg: Parveen vs. Khamidova (Uzb), 2 p.m.; Men’s 60kg: Sachin vs. Kitamoto (Jpn), 2.45 p.m.; Men’s +90kg: Narendra vs. Saengtep (Tha), 3.45 p.m.

Hockey: Women (Pool B): vs. Singapore, 3.30 p.m.

Shooting: 25m pistol women individual qualification and team final (Precision) — Manu, Esha, Rahi, 6.10 a.m.; Trap men individual qualification and team

final (day 1) — Ahvar, Kynan, Shaphat, 6.30 a.m.

Trap women individual qualification and team final (day 1) — Maneesha, Aashima, Neeru, 6.30 a.m.

Squash: Finals: Men: Abhay vs Eain (Mas), 12.30 p.m.; Women: Anahat vs. Sivasangari (Mas), 1.30 p.m.

Volleyball: Men (Pool C): vs. Vietnam, 12.30 p.m.

Weightlifting: Women’s 69kg final (Harjinder), 10 a.m.

DELHI



Congress leader Rahul Gandhi during a meeting with members of the local business community, Raebareli, Uttar Pradesh. PTI

Covering the bases

Last year, the Congress set in motion the Sangathan Srijan Abhiyan, a process of rewiring its district leadership across the country. This year, Rahul Gandhi is undertaking a renewed push towards public engagement bordering on activism, even as district leadership is being freed of past hierarchies. Sandeep Phukan examines the social re-engineering of the grand old party and how it intends to build up to the 2029 parliamentary election

When leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi sat on a dharna at Delhi's Parliament Street police station on August 21 to register a first information report (FIR) along with Sahil Lochab, one of the pellet-gun victims of police action during the students' agitation against paper leaks, he was trying out a new political playbook: sudden, swift action that catches the rival by surprise and pressures the authorities to act.

Exactly a month earlier, the Opposition leader had sat on an unannounced dharna outside the Prime Minister's residence, prompting senior ministers to rush in to listen to the Opposition's demands on the paper-leak issue.

After arriving at the police station around noon, Gandhi spent six hours before the cameras, exchanging words with police officials, eating *kathi* rolls for lunch and giving occasional soundbites to waiting television crews, until senior Home Ministry officials agreed to register an FIR on Lochab's complaint.

As images of Lochab and his mother with Gandhi went viral and the Congress claimed credit, many on social media felt that the Opposition had hit a "purple patch".

But can an individual leader's popularity translate into electoral dividends?

The recurring criticism is that the Congress lacks the organisational strength on the ground to convert goodwill into votes. In Hindi heartland States such as Uttar Pradesh and Bihar, the party's organisational machinery inspires little confidence, even among its supporters.

"While it is correct to argue that electoral victory of an organisation is consolidated by a charismatic leader, the charisma of a leader is translated into votes only if it is backed by organisational strength," says associate professor Kumar Sanjay Singh, who teaches history at Delhi University's Swami Shraddhanand College.

However, this is not how the Congress has worked in the recent past as the party has often won elections riding on popular sentiments and the charisma of the Gandhis.

When the party was in power at the Centre for a decade (2004-2014) and in nearly a dozen States, AICC general secretaries spent more time in Delhi power centres than in States they were meant to handle.

By 2014, when the BJP swept the Lok Sabha polls, the party's organisation was hollowed out and its coffers were near empty.

That explains why the party is undertaking a massive organisational rewiring, alongside social re-engineering, under the Sangathan Srijan Abhiyan (SSA).

Until mid-September, nearly 1,000 District Congress Committee (DCC) presidents have been appointed across 25 States under the SSA. Adopted at the All India Congress Committee (AICC) session in Ahmedabad in April 2025, the exercise has been completed in most States.

Kerala and Assam, where Assembly elections were held earlier this year, are yet to undergo the restructuring.

Rebuilding the base

K.C. Venugopal, general secretary in-charge of organisation, or GSO, who is overseeing the ambitious revival plan, explains how the process works on the ground.

"Senior leaders go as AICC observers to a State



Even if one were to accept Congress's claims of effort to rebuild its organisation from grassroots to the top, especially in the Hindi heartland, whether this will be able to successfully challenge the electoral machine of the RSS-BJP is open to question.

KUMAR SANJAY SINGH
Associate professor, Swami Shraddhanand College, DU



This government is playing with the future of our youth and Rahulji is at the forefront of raising their issues and becoming their voice. We will continue to follow that path and bring about real change.

K.C. VENUGOPAL
Congress general secretary in charge of organisation



and cover the districts where they identify and shortlist potential district committee leaders. They spend about 10-15 days, seeking opinion from workers, eminent citizens, activists and so on," Venugopal says.

He adds that the DCC president is usually appointed from the topmost contenders on a shortlist, which usually contains five or six names. "Only when there are serious differences, we consult Congress Legislature Party and Congress Working Committee (CWC) members. But even then, weightage is given to observers," he says.

The party has made the DCCs the focal point of the proposed turnaround process, with the emphasis on making its presence felt at the grassroots. From giving district offices a fresh coat of paint to framing national issues in local idioms and taking up district-specific concerns, suggestions are pouring in from AICC observers tasked with shortlisting district chiefs who can revive the party.

"In my 30 years in the Congress party, I have not come across such an elaborate exercise that involves leaders at every level," says Ashok Tanwar, a former Haryana Congress chief who re-joined the party after a stint in the BJP.

Tanwar, one of the top 10 AICC observers, who covered districts in Tamil Nadu, Rajasthan, and Uttar Pradesh, says the exercise was not just about appointing DCC chiefs but also about identifying people who could be the party's link with the public. "There are many people who want to selflessly strengthen the party. All we have to do is identify and empower them," he said.

He claims the year-long campaign is beginning to show electoral results. "We have won a majority of the wards in Ajmer after 36 years. This is the power of SSA," says Tanwar, who was the observer for Ajmer, where urban local body polls were held this month.

Monitoring mechanism

Once appointed, the new DCC chiefs are monitored for their performance and effectiveness in carrying forward the party's ideology.

Every observer creates a WhatsApp group of district-level leaders to convey national campaigns as well as local issues.

Leaders are assessed on their participation in party programmes, with regular reports sent to

the GSO. Where a district chief is found wanting, there is provision to replace the leader.

"As and when we see some shortcoming, we make corrections," Venugopal says, pointing to cases in Uttarakhand, Haryana, and Odisha where leaders in some districts will be changed.

District chiefs are graded, with top performers placed in the A category and those in the D category liable to be replaced.

The observers are also marked on a scale of 100. The parameters include the quality of ground reports, choice of potential district chiefs, interaction with civil society, reporting of activities, and integrity and conduct.

"This campaign has certainly helped us rejuvenate the party at the lowest level. People at booth and block levels feel assured that the AICC is listening to their grievances," says Abdul Khaleque, former Lok Sabha member from Assam, who has been ranked the best-performing AICC observer. "At times factionalism, even at the most basic tier of the party structure, poses a challenge," says Khaleque, who was an observer for Madhya Pradesh, Jharkhand and West Bengal.

Intense factionalism is a product of entrenched hierarchies that do not accept change easily. There were no district-level committees in Haryana for 12 years.

Though powerful leaders such as Ghulam Nabi Azad, Kamal Nath, and Shakeel Ahmad were general secretaries in-charge of the State, they failed to build an effective organisation amid factionalism promoted by the satraps.

"The SSA is a policy decision of the party and everyone has to accept it. It is always better than an individual effort. That's why everyone in Haryana comes under one umbrella," says Tanwar.

Observers who do not want to be identified say they have witnessed underlying tensions between the old guard and younger leaders in States such as Madhya Pradesh, Punjab, and Rajasthan.

The silver lining, many say, is that the high command is mostly listening to the ground.

"In one or two cases, there are some suggestions to change the names that come up from the ground, but the party leadership goes with the observer's recommendations," says B.P. Singh, another top-performing observer, who travelled to Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Punjab, and Himachal Pradesh.



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ASHOK TANWAR
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ABDUL KHALEQUE
Former Lok Sabha member from Assam

Prof. Singh says that the Congress is out-matched by the organisational network of RSS-BJP in the Hindi heartland.

"Even if one were to accept Congress's claims of effort to rebuild its organisation from grassroots to the top, especially in the Hindi heartland, whether this will be able to successfully challenge the electoral machine of the RSS-BJP is open to question," he notes.

Securing social justice

While established leaders push for their acolytes, AICC observers have also been mandated to find effective leaders while ensuring representation for Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, Other Backward Classes, minorities, and women.

An analysis of the 830 DCC presidents appointed until the end of August shows that 553, or 66.6%, belonged to SC, ST, OBC and minority communities. This is an increase of nearly 10% points over the earlier composition of district-level leadership.

Only 57 of the 830, or about 7%, are women. At the same time, 415, or 50%, of the new chiefs are below 50, in line with a resolution adopted by the party at Udaipur in 2022.

"We are not saying that the process is perfect but we are making a sincere attempt to change and get battle ready," says Venugopal. The battle he speaks about is the Parliamentary election of 2029.

Getting battle-ready

With the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls becoming one of the most contentious political issues, preparing booth-level agents from among the 16 lakh office-bearers is the top priority. The party wants a trained cadre capable of detecting alleged electoral malpractice.

After the Gen Z protests at Jantar Mantar over paper leaks, the thrust of the Congress's campaign has shifted towards youth outreach.

At its meeting on August 19, the Congress Working Committee approved a plan to expand Chhatron Ki Goonj (that loosely translates from Hindi to a student reverberation) to as many as 800 cities over the next few months.

This is an attempt to turn a series of student interactions into a nationwide programme.

Gandhi is likely to address as many as 28 student-interaction programmes under the campaign as the party seeks to build sustained outreach among young voters ahead of the 2029 Lok Sabha election. Gen Z could account for roughly 25-30% of India's voting population by 2029, according to some demographic projections.

"This government is playing with the future of our youth and Rahulji is at the forefront of raising their issues and becoming their voice. We will continue to follow that path and bring about real change," Venugopal says.

The real test

Appointing DCC presidents and grading observers, and maintaining WhatsApp groups may bring discipline to a party whose structure has often been allowed to drift, but none of these measures by itself guarantees an active booth-level cadre.

The Congress has attempted several rounds of organisational renewal in the past, and State-level factionalism, the dominance of established leaders and the gap between the high command and the grassroots, have blunted them, say political commentators.

Greater representation of younger leaders and of SC, ST, OBC, and minority communities may widen the social base, but representation will have to translate into authority, resources, and electoral responsibility.

"Rahul has successfully built a narrative to stitch together a multilateral alliance, by bringing social justice, educational reform, and employment to the centre of the political discourse. He has also tapped into the populist psyche of the middle classes and the poor by launching a sharp critique on crony capitalism," Prof. Singh says, admitting that the response to Rahul's attacks on crony capitalism is at best tepid even within Congress.

The same applies to its student outreach efforts. The failure of the Congress's student wing, National Students Union of India, to win any seat in the students' body polls of the Delhi University Students' Union (DUSU) shows that perceived popularity or visibility of its leader is not enough to win elections.

The Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad, the student wing of the RSS, swept the DUSU polls. The DUSU setback is even more striking since it comes in a period when the Congress, since the Gen Z protests in July, is trying to build a narrative that the youth are moving away from the BJP.

"Since the Gen Z movement is triggered in Delhi, ABVP's electoral defeat would have gone a long way in consolidating this narrative," says Prof. Singh. He claims that the BJP reacted to this challenge with alacrity and Prime Minister Narendra Modi returned to the Shri Ram College of Commerce (SRCC), which had helmed his campaign in 2013, the year before he became Prime Minister.

"This time he spoke at the centenary celebrations of the college on September 5, just a fortnight before the DUSU election. The Congress, on the other hand, treats it as a run-of-the-mill election and misses the significance of timing in changing the momentum of politics," adds the academic.

For a party that has spent much of the past decade struggling to arrest its organisational decline, the Congress is attempting something beyond filling vacant posts, by changing the way its organisation is built – beginning not with the State leadership but with the district, block, and booth. The real test, however, will come at election time, when the new organisational architecture will be put to the test.

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